

A person literate in any one language was regarded as literate. Information on the specific language in which a person was literate was not obtained in the 1971 Census although it had been obtained in the Censuses of 1963 and 1953. In all three censuses, there was no objective test of the ability of a person to read and write; the enumerator accepted the respondent's declaration. It might therefore be assumed that there could have been a tendency on the part of some respondents to overstate their abilities for the sake of prestige. It will of course be possible to ascertain whether such a tendency exists by tracing and comparing the literacy rate of a cohort (group of persons in a certain age group) of persons at each of the successive censuses.

Table 8.1 presents the literacy rates of the cohort aged 20-49 at the 1946 Census. This cohort of persons (except for those who died during the intercensal period) would have moved into the 27-56 age group in 1953, the 37-66 age group in 1963 and 45-74 in 1971. The literacy rates of this cohort given in the table for both sexes together as well as for each sex separately show a fair degree of consistency from one census to the next. The rates are very nearly equal at the 1946 and 1971 Censuses. The rate was 647 per 1000 persons in 1946 and 646 in 1971, the difference being only 1. The figures for males and females considered separately are also highly consistent.

Although slightly higher rates of literacy were recorded in the 1953 and 1963 Censuses, the differences are not sufficiently large to render the data unreliable. It must, however, be borne in mind that this consistency in the literacy rates could have also been due to the proportion of persons in the cohort wrongly reporting themselves as literate remaining the same at each census. Even if this were so, the literacy rates are still comparable from census to census and the increase in literacy rates over the years may be deemed genuine.

TABLE 8.1 : LITERACY RATES OF THE COHORT AGED 20-49 IN 1946 TRACED THROUGH THE CENSUSES OF 1953, 1963 & 1971.

Age group of the cohort at the census		1946 20-49	1953 27-56	1963 37-66	1971 45-74
Persons in age Group	T	2,779,054	2,577,658	2,222,931	1,961,092
	M	1,508,421	1,425,328	1,233,023	1,070,589
	F	1,270,633	1,152,330	989,908	890,503
Number literate	T	1,799,182	1,712,400	1,520,452	1,266,116
	M	1,209,047	1,145,529	1,011,231	850,330
	F	590,135	566,871	509,221	415,786
Literacy rate per 1000 persons	T	647	664	684	646
	M	802	804	820	794
	F	464	492	514	467

8.3 Literacy rates at the 1971 Census

Of the 9,354,303 persons aged 10 years and over enumerated at the 1971 Census, as many as 7,344,531 persons or 78.5 percent were literate. Among those who were literate, 4,143,302 or 56.4 percent were males and 3,201,229 or 43.6 percent were females giving ratio of 130 male literates for every 100 female

made from census to census.